TRAVELSCOUT · PROJECT DOCUMENT

Project charter

The agreement on what TravelScout is for, how it is delivered and how it is judged.

PROJECT
TravelScout

PREPARED BY
Aditi Kela, product lead

VERSION
1.0, draft for review

DATE
October 15, 2026

CONFIRMED from the built app or from you ESTIMATE my working figure
PROPOSED a plan or target to test SOURCED from a cited public page TO CONFIRM needs your input

PROJECT
TravelScout, an AI-powered group trip-planning app CONFIRMED

OWNER
Aditi Kela CONFIRMED

ORIGIN
Started in the Northeastern course on semantic intelligence (INFO 7375) CONFIRMED

STATUS
Working app CONFIRMED

NAME IN THE APP
The browser tab still reads "TripMate AI"; rename to match TO CONFIRM

Purpose

Group trips are planned across chat threads, spreadsheets and links, and prices go stale. TravelScout gives each trip one room. Everyone joins with a trip code, shares budget, interests, pace and dietary needs, and plans together in one chat with an AI travel guide that proposes flights and stays with price estimates, a checked date and a source link. CONFIRMED

Objectives

#	OBJECTIVE	MEASURE	TARGET	BASIS
1	Deliver the core planning room	Features live: group chat, AI planner, flights and hotels, itinerary, polls, weather	6 of 6	CONFIRMED Met
2	Make price information honest	Share of prices shown with a checked date and a source link	100%	CONFIRMED Met

#	OBJECTIVE	MEASURE	TARGET	BASIS
3	Capture each traveler's needs	Preference form fields: budget, interests, pace, dietary, accessibility	5 of 5	CONFIRMED Met
4	Test with real groups	Groups that plan a trip end to end	5 groups of 3 to 6 people	PROPOSED
5	Prove the AI guide helps	Travelers who say the guide saved time	At least 70%	PROPOSED
6	Keep AI cost per trip small	Cost per planned trip	Under $1 ESTIMATE	ESTIMATE

Deliverables

- Working app with trip rooms, join codes, group chat and an AI travel guide CONFIRMED
- Flight and hotel estimates labeled with the date checked and a source link CONFIRMED
- Plan, polls, itinerary and expenses tabs CONFIRMED
- Six desktop screenshots for the portfolio CONFIRMED
- Group test report PROPOSED

Roles

WHO	ROLE	BASIS
Aditi Kela	Product, design and build owner	CONFIRMED
Northeastern course INFO 7375	Where the project started	CONFIRMED
Test groups	Plan a real or mock trip and give feedback	PROPOSED

Timeline

Durations are project weeks. The completed phases are my reconstruction of the effort and need correction. TO CONFIRM

PHASE	WHAT HAPPENS	DURATION	STATUS	BASIS
1. Define	Problem, users, feature list, success criteria	1 week	Complete	ESTIMATE
2. Design	Screens for home, start-a-trip, trip room, preferences	2 weeks	Complete	ESTIMATE
3. Build core	Trip rooms with join codes, group chat, preferences	3 weeks	Complete	ESTIMATE
4. Build AI guide	Guide asks questions, proposes flights and stays with estimates, date and source	3 weeks	Complete	ESTIMATE
5. Build tabs	Itinerary, polls, weather and expenses	2 weeks	Complete	ESTIMATE
6. Rename and polish	Fix the app name, remove stray characters in chat, tidy copy	1 week	Next	PROPOSED
7. Group tests	5 groups plan a trip; collect feedback	3 weeks	Planned	PROPOSED
8. Improve	Fix top issues; decide on features such as expense splitting depth	3 weeks	Planned	PROPOSED

Risks

RISK	LIKELIHOOD	IMPACT	MITIGATION
Price estimates are wrong or stale	High	High	Keep the "estimate, verify before booking" label, show the checked date, re-check on open
AI invents a flight or hotel	Medium	High	Only show items that have a source link; hide any result without one
Cost per trip climbs with long chats	Medium	Medium	Use the smaller model for routine replies; cap turns per trip
Groups prefer apps they already use	High	Medium	Make joining one link; import from chat later
Name confusion (TripMate AI versus TravelScout)	High	Low	Rename the app title and tab

Assumptions

- Prices are planning estimates, not booking prices. CONFIRMED
- Group trips of 3 to 6 people are the target. PROPOSED

Approval

NAME	ROLE	VERSION	DATE
Aditi Kela	Product, design and build owner	1.0, draft for review	October 15, 2026

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Scope statement

The edge of TravelScout's first release, and what stays out.

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Scope in one paragraph

One room per trip. Travelers join with a code, set their preferences and plan together in one chat with an AI travel guide. Tabs hold the plan, polls, itinerary and expenses so decisions stay near the conversation. CONFIRMED

Requirements

ID	REQUIREMENT	PRIORITY	STATUS	BASIS
R1	Start a trip with destination, dates, travelers and budget	Must	Built	CONFIRMED
R2	Others join with a trip code	Must	Built	CONFIRMED
R3	Personal preferences: budget, interests, pace, dietary and accessibility needs	Must	Built	CONFIRMED
R4	Group chat	Must	Built	CONFIRMED
R5	AI guide asks questions, then proposes flights and stays with estimates	Must	Built	CONFIRMED
R6	Each price shows the checked date and a source link, and a reminder to verify	Must	Built	CONFIRMED
R7	Day-by-day itinerary	Must	Built	CONFIRMED
R8	Polls	Should	Built	CONFIRMED
R9	Weather	Should	Built	CONFIRMED
R10	Expenses tab	Should	Built (depth TO CONFIRM)	CONFIRMED
R11	Rename app title from TripMate AI to TravelScout	Must	Open	TO CONFIRM
R12	Remove stray "0" and "00" displays between chat messages	Must	Open	TO CONFIRM
R13	Booking links out to partners	Could	Not started	PROPOSED

ID	REQUIREMENT	PRIORITY	STATUS	BASIS
R14	Import reservations from email	Could	Not started	PROPOSED

Out of scope

- Booking and payment inside the app PROPOSED
- Visa, insurance or medical advice PROPOSED
- Native mobile apps PROPOSED
- Loyalty points and rewards tracking PROPOSED
- Guaranteeing any price CONFIRMED

Acceptance criteria

AREA	ACCEPTED WHEN
Join	A new traveler joins with the code and sets preferences in under 3 minutes
AI guide	The guide asks at least the destination, dates and budget before proposing options, and every option has a source link
Prices	Every price shows a date and is labeled as an estimate
Polls	A poll created by one traveler is visible to all and shows results
Itinerary	Chosen items appear on the correct day

Constraints

- Solo builder, coursework origin. CONFIRMED
- Price sources depend on what the data tools can reach. TO CONFIRM
- Costs must stay small while users are few. ESTIMATE

Change control

1. Write the change and the reason.
2. Score with MoSCoW.
3. Add only Musts, or swap with an equal item.
4. Record the decision.

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User research plan and template

A ready-to-run plan for learning how groups plan trips today. Findings stay empty until sessions happen.

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> No research findings exist yet for this project, so none are written here. TO CONFIRM

Goals

- Understand how groups of friends or family plan a trip today.
- Find where planning breaks down: choosing dates, budget, places, food, who pays.
- Test whether sourced, dated price estimates build trust.
- Learn whether an AI guide in the group chat is welcome.

Research questions

#	QUESTION	DECISION IT INFORMS
RQ1	Which tools do groups use, and where does it go wrong?	Which tabs matter most
RQ2	How do groups decide (polls, one organizer, long threads)?	Poll design
RQ3	How much do travelers trust AI-suggested prices and plans?	Source and date display
RQ4	How do dietary needs and pace differences get handled?	Preference form
RQ5	How is money handled during and after a trip?	Expenses depth

Method

METHOD	SAMPLE	LENGTH
Interview	8 people who planned a group trip in the last year	30 minutes

METHOD	SAMPLE	LENGTH
Group test	3 groups of 3 to 6 who are planning a real or mock trip	45 minutes
Survey	30 or more responses	4 minutes

> Sample sizes are my proposal. PROPOSED

Screener

1. Have you planned or joined a trip with 3 or more people in the past 12 months?
2. Who organized it, and how many people went?
3. Which tools did you use?
4. Do you or anyone in your group have dietary or accessibility needs that affect planning?
5. Are you comfortable being recorded for notes?

Interview guide (30 minutes)

TIME	PROMPTS
0:00	Opening, consent, "Tell me about your last group trip."
0:05	"How did the idea turn into a plan?" "Where did people disagree?" "What did you wish you had earlier?"
0:13	"How did you pick flights and stays?" "How did you know prices were current?" "Did price change after you decided?"
0:20	"How did you handle food and accessibility needs?" "How did you split costs?"
0:25	"Would you let an AI suggest options in your group chat? What would make you trust it?"
0:28	Wrap-up and thanks.

Group test script (45 minutes)

1. Organizer creates a trip with destination, dates, travelers and budget.
2. Others join with the code and fill their preferences.
3. The group asks the guide for flights and stays; ask them to decide whether to trust each price.
4. The group creates one poll and picks the winner.
5. They add two items to the itinerary and check the weather.
6. Debrief: "What was confusing?" "What would you use again?"

Measures

MEASURE	HOW
Time to join	Seconds from code entry to preferences saved
Trust in prices (1 to 5)	Ask after the guide shows estimates
Polls used	Count of poll votes
Task success	Completed without help (yes/no)

MEASURE	HOW
Would use again (yes/no)	Debrief

Survey (10 questions)

1. How many group trips in the last year?
2. Group size.
3. Tools used for planning (multi-select).
4. Biggest planning frustration (open).
5. How do you decide (poll, one person decides, discussion)?
6. How do you check price accuracy?
7. Would you trust an AI-suggested price with a date and source? (1 to 5)
8. Do you or your group have dietary or accessibility needs?
9. How do you split expenses?
0. Would you use a shared planning room? (yes/maybe/no; why)

Consent and care

- Explain recording and storage; use participant codes.
- Do not ask for passport, payment or booking details.
- Delete recordings after synthesis.

Note-taking template

PARTICIPANT	DATE	GROUP SIZE	QUOTE	OBSERVATION	THEME	NEED OR PAIN
P01						
P02						

Synthesis

1. Notes to affinity groups.
2. Name themes as sentences.
3. Count participants per theme; 3 or more is a pattern.
4. Turn patterns into insights and changes to scope.

Findings log (complete after sessions)

THEME	PARTICIPANTS	EVIDENCE	INSIGHT	CHANGE

Schedule

WEEK	ACTIVITY
1	Recruit, finalize guide, pilot once
2	Interviews and group tests

WEEK	ACTIVITY
3	Survey, synthesis, report

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Ideation and prioritization

How the idea space was opened up and which ideas rank first.

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Problem statement

Groups plan trips across chat threads, spreadsheets and links, and nobody trusts that prices are current. How might one shared room hold the conversation, the preferences, the options and the plan, with prices that show when and where they were checked? CONFIRMED

How might we

- HMW get every traveler's needs on the table before options are proposed?
- HMW let a group decide without a 200-message thread?
- HMW show prices honestly?
- HMW keep the plan near the conversation?
- HMW handle money without awkwardness?

Proto-personas

> Hypotheses built from the product idea. Replace after research. PROPOSED

	DANA, THE ORGANIZER	SAM, THE QUIET TRAVELER
Situation	Plans a trip for six friends and chases answers	Joins late, has dietary needs, rarely speaks up in group chat
Needs	One place to collect preferences and decide	A form to state needs without asking in public
Worries	Stale prices, flaky replies	Being left with a plan that does not work for them

Jobs to be done

- When I plan a trip with friends, I want everyone's needs in one place so I do not guess.

- When we compare flights, I want to see how recent the price is so I can trust it.
- When we disagree, I want a quick vote so we move on.

Ideas considered

THEME	IDEA	STATUS
Collect	Join code; preference form	Built CONFIRMED
Discuss	Group chat; AI guide that asks questions	Built CONFIRMED
Decide	Polls	Built CONFIRMED
Plan	Itinerary; weather	Built CONFIRMED
Money	Estimates with date and source; expenses tab	Built CONFIRMED
Extend	Email import; booking links; read-only share link	PROPOSED

Prioritization (RICE)

Reach is travelers per year in the first test pool. Impact 0.5 to 3. Confidence as a percentage. Effort in person-weeks. All numbers are my proposals. PROPOSED

RANK	IDEA	REACH	IMPACT	CONFIDENCE	EFFORT	RICE SCORE
1	Dated, sourced price estimates	10,000	3.0	90%	2	13,500.0
2	Group polls	10,000	2.0	80%	2	8,000.0
3	Preference form for dietary and accessibility needs	10,000	2.0	80%	2	8,000.0
4	Shareable read-only itinerary link	10,000	1.0	80%	1	8,000.0
5	Expense splitting with settle-up summary	8,000	2.0	70%	4	2,800.0
6	Booking links out to partners	8,000	1.5	60%	4	1,800.0
7	Group budget guardrail warnings	6,000	1.5	60%	3	1,800.0
8	Import reservations from email	5,000	1.5	50%	6	625.0

MoSCoW

MUST	SHOULD	COULD	WILL NOT (NOW)
Sourced, dated prices	Settle-up summary	Email import	In-app booking
Join code and preferences	Read-only itinerary link	Budget guardrails	Payments
AI guide with sources	Polls	Booking links	Native apps

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Competitive analysis

What group travelers can use today and where TravelScout fits.

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> Research accessed October 15, 2026. "Not found" means the page read did not say so. Third-party sources are marked. Tripadvisor and Google Travel were not covered. SOURCED

Overview

APP	WHAT IT IS	COLLABORATION	AI PLANNING	PRICES SHOWN	EXPENSE SPLITTING	PRICING
Wanderlog	Collaborative itinerary and map planner	Yes, real time; edit or view-only invites	Yes; one third-party source puts it in Pro	Hotel suggestions compared on price; flight prices not found; date and source not found	Yes, budgeting tool splits costs	Free; Pro $39.99/yr (third party)
TripIt	Organizes plans into one itinerary	Sharing of plans; real-time collaboration not found	Not found	Not found	Not found	Free; Pro $49/yr
Mindtrip	AI travel assistant that plans and books	Group planning, invites; group chat per a 2024 article (third party)	Yes	Yes, with price-drop alerts; no date checked or data provider shown	Not found	Not found
Layla	AI planner with optional human advisor	Not found	Yes	Real-time comparison claimed; date and source not found	Not found	Planning free; about $49/yr tier per its blog

APP	WHAT IT IS	COLLABORATION	AI PLANNING	PRICES SHOWN	EXPENSE SPLITTING	PRICING
Splitwise	Expense splitting	Group ledgers with comments	Not found	Not found	Yes, several split types, 100+ currencies	Free (4 expenses a day); Pro and Trip Pass, amounts not found

Feature gap

FEATURE	WANDERLOG	TRIPIT	MINDTRIP	LAYLA	SPLITWISE	TRAVELSCOUT
Group chat in the planning space	Not found	Not found	Group chat (2024 article)	Not found	Comments	Yes CONFIRMED
Polls or voting	Not found	Not found	Not found	Not found	Not found	Yes CONFIRMED
AI guide that asks questions first	Not found	Not found	Not found	Not found	Not found	Yes CONFIRMED
Preferences for budget, pace, dietary and accessibility	Not found	Not found	Not found	Not found	Not found	Yes CONFIRMED
Prices with date checked and source link	Not found	Not found	Not found	Not found	Not found	Yes CONFIRMED
Itinerary	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	Yes CONFIRMED
Expense splitting	Yes	Not found	Not found	Not found	Yes	Tab built; depth TO CONFIRM
Mobile apps	Yes	Yes	iOS	Not found	Yes	Web CONFIRMED

Where competitors are stronger

- Wanderlog: maps, real-time editing and email import, with mobile apps.
- TripIt: reservation import and flight alerts.
- Mindtrip: booking inside the app and price-drop alerts.
- Splitwise: a mature expense engine.

Where TravelScout can stand apart

- An AI guide in the group chat that asks first and shows its source, date and an estimate label.
- Preferences that include dietary and accessibility needs.
- Polls next to the conversation.
- The gap on dated, sourced prices is a gap in what I read, not proof that no competitor does it.

Implications

- Lead with trust: every price carries a date and a source. PROPOSED

- Do not try to outdo Wanderlog on maps. PROPOSED
- Add email import and a share link after group tests. PROPOSED
- Keep expense splitting simple, or link out to Splitwise. PROPOSED

Sources

- Wanderlog: apps.apple.com/us/app/wanderlog/id1476732439; wanderlog.com/trip-planner-ai; help.wanderlog.com/hc/en-us/articles/13302997563547-Is-Wanderlog-free; whistleout.com (published 2026-03-09, third party); monkeyeatingmango.com/blog/wanderlog-pricing-2026/ (third party, author makes a competing product); stardrift.ai/resources/wanderlog (2026-07-17)
- TripIt: tripit.com/uhp/pricing
- Mindtrip: mindtrip.ai/; mindtrip.ai/flights; resources.mindtrip.ai/travelers/help/traveler-faqs; phocuswire.com/mindtrip-secures-12m-funding-launches-group-chat (2024-09-18)
- Layla: layla.ai/about; layla.ai/blog/news-and-tips/best-free-ai-trip-planner
- Splitwise: apps.apple.com/app/id458023433; kb.splitwise.com/pro/what-is-splitwise-pro-and-who-can-use-it

Limits

- Wanderlog Pro pricing is third-party only.
- Mindtrip group chat may have changed since 2024.
- Layla's pricing statements conflict.
- Splitwise Pro dollar prices were not readable.

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Growth plan

How TravelScout could reach its first groups. Targets are proposals.

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> No usage data yet. Targets are proposals to test. TO CONFIRM

Position

The planning room where every price shows when and where it was checked. PROPOSED

Audience

- Students and young professionals who plan trips with friends. PROPOSED
- Families with mixed dietary or accessibility needs. PROPOSED

North Star

Trips with a final itinerary created by two or more travelers. It shows the group used the room together. PROPOSED

METRIC	WHY	STARTING TARGET
Rooms created	Reach	100 in 90 days
Travelers per room	Group adoption	At least 3
Rooms with a poll decided	Collaboration	40%
Rooms with an itinerary	Completion	50%
Prices opened via source link	Trust	Track

Funnel

STAGE	MEASURE	IDEA
Awareness	Visits	Short clip of the guide asking questions first

STAGE	MEASURE	IDEA
Acquisition	Rooms created	One-click start with defaults
Activation	Second traveler joins	Share the trip code from the first screen
Retention	Return to the room within 7 days	Reminders for open polls
Referral	Travelers who start their own room	Read-only itinerary link with a start-your-own prompt
Revenue	Interest in paid features	Test booking links or a premium itinerary export

Loop

An organizer invites friends with a code. Friends fill their preferences, see value, and start their own room for the next trip. PROPOSED

Channels

CHANNEL	FIT	COST
Student groups and clubs planning trips	High	Time
Friend groups of the builder and classmates	High	Time
Short videos of the guide	Medium	Time
Travel subreddits (with rules respected)	Low to medium	Time

Experiments

#	HYPOTHESIS	TEST	SUCCESS
1	The sourced-price label raises trust	Compare ratings with and without source link	Trust rating up by one point
2	Sharing the code on the first screen raises second-traveler joins	A/B the screen	Joins up by 25%
3	Poll reminders raise polls decided	Remind after 24 hours	Decided polls up by 15 points

90-day plan

DAYS	FOCUS	OUTPUT
1 to 30	Rename, fix bugs, run group tests	Test report
31 to 60	Fix top issues; add share link	Improved onboarding
61 to 90	Open to 10 student groups; measure	First growth readout

Risks

- Low switching incentive if friends already use another app.
- Wrong prices damage trust quickly.
- AI cost rises with long chats.

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Budget

What TravelScout costs to run now and at 50, 500 and 2,000 planned trips a month.

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> Prices come from public pages read on the dates shown. Usage and hosting numbers are my estimates. ESTIMATE

Pricing inputs

ITEM	PRICE	SOURCE	BASIS
Claude Sonnet 5.5	$2 input, $10 output per million tokens	platform.claude.com/docs/en/about-claude/pricing, read 2026-10-15	SOURCED
Claude Haiku 5.5	$0.10 input, $0.50 output per million tokens (prompts up to 100K)	Same page	SOURCED
Web search or price lookup tools	Not priced here	Check the pricing page for tool charges before launch	TO CONFIRM
Hosting	Not confirmed	Confirm where the app is hosted	TO CONFIRM
Domain	About $12 to $20 a year	General market range	ESTIMATE

Usage assumptions

- A planned trip uses about 40 AI turns, each with about 3,000 input and 700 output tokens, including the group context. ESTIMATE
- Price and source lookups are extra and not included. ESTIMATE

AI cost per month

TRIPS A MONTH	AI TURNS	SONNET 5.5	HAIKU 5.5
50	2,000	$26.00	$1.30

TRIPS A MONTH	AI TURNS	SONNET 5.5	HAIKU 5.5
500	20,000	$260.00	$13.00
2,000	80,000	$1,040.00	$52.00

Per trip: $0.52 with Sonnet and $0.03 with Haiku. ESTIMATE

Other costs

ITEM	COST	NOTES	BASIS
Hosting	$0 to $50 a month	Free tier at small scale; confirm	ESTIMATE
Weather and price data	$0 to $50 a month	Depends on provider limits	ESTIMATE
Group test thank-yous	$100 to $200	3 groups, 4 people each, $10 to $15	ESTIMATE
Contingency	15% on top		PROPOSED

Cost controls

- Cache price results for the checked date so repeated questions do not re-search.
- Use the smaller model for routine chat; keep the larger model for plan building.
- Cap turns per room per day.
- Set a monthly spending limit with an alert.

Open items

- Confirm hosting and data providers. TO CONFIRM
- Confirm how prices are sourced and any tool charges. TO CONFIRM